

DEHYDRATING AND SMOKING

Adults

Q

What is the recommended dehydrator air temperature for drying fruit leathers like mango puree?

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ANSWER

140°F

FUN FACT

Maintaining the right temperature helps ensure the fruit leather dries evenly and safely.

Source: SP 50-921 Drying herbs

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Why must jerky be heated to 275°F for 10 minutes after drying?

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ANSWER

To kill harmful microorganisms that survive drying

FUN FACT

Post-drying heating is one of two safe methods to ensure jerky safety.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

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What minimum internal temperature must hot-smoked fish reach and be held for at least 30 minutes?

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ANSWER

150°F (preferably 160°F)

FUN FACT

*Proper cooking during smoking prevents dangerous bacteria like *Clostridium botulinum*.*

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

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What is a pellicle in the context of smoking fish?

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ANSWER

A shiny, slightly tacky skin on the fish surface that helps smoke adhere

FUN FACT

Forming a pellicle is crucial for evenly smoked and properly preserved fish.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

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How long should larger or oily fish pieces be brined before smoking?

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ANSWER

About 2 hours

FUN FACT

Proper brining ensures uniform salt uptake and safer smoked fish.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

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What salt concentration is commonly used in the brining solution for fish smoking?

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ANSWER

**1 part table salt to 7 parts
water by volume**

FUN FACT

*This brine usually measures about 60°
SAL on a salometer.*

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

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Why is it important to rinse cured pork belly thoroughly after the curing process when making bacon?

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ANSWER

To remove excess surface salt and brine for balanced flavor

FUN FACT

Rinsing does not remove curing salts from inside the meat, only surface residues.

Source: PNW 784 Making bacon at home

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What ingredient in dry curing bacon acts as a curing salt to inhibit bacterial growth?

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ANSWER

Curing Salt #1 (Prague Powder #1)

FUN FACT

Curing salts contain nitrites which help preserve color and prevent botulism.

Source: PNW 784 Making bacon at home

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Why should fish pieces be of uniform size and thickness before smoking?

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ANSWER

To ensure uniform salt uptake and cooking

FUN FACT

Uneven pieces may lead to under- or over-salted and potentially unsafe fish.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

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What is a major food safety risk if homemade jerky is dried at temperatures around 140°F-155°F without further treatment?

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ANSWER

Pathogens may survive and cause foodborne illness

FUN FACT

Low drying temperatures create environments ideal for microbial growth without additional heating.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

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What is the purpose of conditioning jerky after drying and heating?

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ANSWER

To equalize moisture and prevent molding

FUN FACT

Proper conditioning ensures even moisture distribution before packaging.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

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What moisture content is desired in properly dried fruits and vegetables for safe storage?

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ANSWER

Low enough to prevent microbial growth, typically under 20%

FUN FACT

Moisture removal is essential to prevent spoilage and ensure shelf stability.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables

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Why must smoked fish be stored under refrigeration at 38°F or less?

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ANSWER

To prevent growth of harmful bacteria after smoking

FUN FACT

Even properly smoked fish can support bacterial growth if not refrigerated safely.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

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What is the main reason for adjusting drying times based on altitude?

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ANSWER

Lower air pressure at higher altitudes changes drying rates

FUN FACT

Drying longer or at slightly higher temperatures may be needed at high altitudes.

Source: SP 50-921 Drying herbs

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Which of these actions should NOT be done when drying herbs at home?

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ANSWER

Dry herbs with wet leaves still attached

FUN FACT

Moisture on herbs before drying can cause mold or spoilage.

Source: SP 50-921 Drying herbs

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What is a primary reason cold-smoked fish is considered riskier than hot-smoked fish?

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ANSWER

Cold smoking does not cook or kill pathogens

FUN FACT

Cold-smoked fish requires careful handling to avoid foodborne illness.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

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How long does it take to dry fruit leather made from mango puree at 140°F?

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ANSWER

About 10 hours

FUN FACT

Drying time varies based on humidity but should leave no sticky spots.

Source: SP 50-921 Drying herbs

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Why should fish not overlap during brining for smoking?

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ANSWER

To ensure uniform salt absorption

FUN FACT

Overlapping fish pieces can lead to uneven curing and unsafe product.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

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What happens if dried fruits are not stored in airtight containers?

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ANSWER

They can reabsorb moisture and spoil

FUN FACT

Airtight storage extends shelf life by keeping moisture out.

Source: SP 50-587 Enjoying home dried fruits vegetables

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Which treatment ensures safe jerky even if using ground meat where bacteria can spread?

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ANSWER

**Precooking meat before drying
or heating after drying**

FUN FACT

Ground meat requires extra safety steps due to pathogen distribution.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely